

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

THE PURGE IS ON

It's only April, but the Gujarat Congress is already feeling the heat. Rahul Gandhi made a second visit here in a week and the overarching chorus was to identify the '*gaddars*' (traitors) working as the BJP's B-team. Rahul has given an ultimatum—the rogue elements must be purged. Several informal lists of suspected turncoats are now doing the rounds, but the question remains—were state leaders such as PCC chief Shaktisinh Gohil, legislative party leader Amit Chavda and AICC in-charge Mukul Wasnik unaware of the goings-on in the state? Conversely, if they knew, why wasn't action taken?

BIHAR CALLING

At 11.39 am on April 19, LJP (Ram Vilas) state president Raju Tewari extended the first overture—a quote from party chief **Chirag Paswan**—on X: 'Bihar is calling me.' Three hours later—time enough, some murmured, to test the waters—he fired off a second communiqué: '*Chirag ke swagat ko Bihar hai taiyyar* (Bihar is ready to welcome Chirag)'. This one raised a few eyebrows, but more among the ruling coalition colleagues. After all, in 2020, Chirag had gone rogue, fielding candidates against the JD(U) and consigning Nitish Kumar to his party's lowest tally since 2005. Now, with whispers of a home-state candidacy, and Chirag's recent avowal that, unlike his father, he intends to return to Bihar state politics at some point, analysts say the signs point to a credible tilt at the top job in Patna. One suspects the Nitish camp has taken due note.



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ALL SHOOK UP



In a late-night shake-up on April 21, the Uttar Pradesh government transferred 33 IAS officers. But it's the exit of **Shishir Singh** as director, information, that created all the buzz in Lucknow. A long-time Yogi Adityanath confidant, Shishir's transfer comes days after a fiery outburst by state minister Ashish Patel, husband of Union minister and Apna Dal chief Anupriya Patel, who accused him of running a smear campaign. The Patels are said to be quietly celebrating, their political muscle seemingly flexed to full effect.





THE CM'S MAN

Maharashtra CM **Devendra Fadnavis's** move to appoint ex-IAS officer **Praveen Pardeshi** as chief economic advisor has led to buzz that it is an attempt to clip the wings of deputy CM and finance minister Ajit Pawar. Already, the other deputy CM, Eknath Shinde, seems a shadow of his former self. Is it Ajit's turn now, and is Pardeshi, the man seen as the CM's blue-eyed boy, the cat's paw in the finance department?

A SECOND INNINGS

In an unexpected romantic turn in Bengal's political theatre, ex-BJP state president **Dilip Ghosh**, 60, married party colleague Rinku Majumdar in a quiet ceremony in Kolkata on April 18. Dressed in traditional Bengali attire and a topor, Ghosh and his bride thanked well-wishers—including CM Mamata Banerjee—for their blessings. The couple first met during morning walks at Eco Park in 2021; the friendship gradually turned into love. In a filmi twist, it was Rinku who proposed—during an IPL match this April. Senior BJP leaders turned up to greet the couple (though party rival Suvendu Adhikari chose silence), and even TMC leaders extended good wishes. And the honeymoon? Ghosh said, "Somewhere in the country."



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Kaushik Deka with Jumana Shah, Amitabh Srivastava, Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar and Avaneesh Mishra